

Summary - Study Guide

Keep the whole meaning while removing what the reader does not need.

Learning goal

Choose or create a concise summary that preserves the passage's central idea, the most important supporting points, and the relationships among them - without adding opinions or unnecessary details.

What this skill really means

A summary is a compressed version of a text. It should let someone understand the passage's essential meaning without reading every example, statistic, quotation, or minor event.

The best summary is not simply the shortest answer. It is the shortest answer that still keeps the passage's important structure: what happened, what the author explains, or how the main ideas are connected.

Term	What it does	What to watch for
Main idea	States the passage's central point	Usually one sentence; does not include all major details.
Summary	Keeps the central point plus essential supporting information	Includes only details needed to understand the whole text.

Retelling	Repeats many details in order	Usually too long and detail-heavy for a summary question.
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How GED-style questions ask it

- Which statement best summarizes the passage?
- Which choice best summarizes paragraphs 3-5?
- Which statement gives the most accurate summary of the author's explanation?

The compression test

1. Find the central idea first. If you do not know what the passage is mainly saying, you cannot judge which details deserve to stay.

2. Mark the essential moves. Ask what changed, what caused what, what problem and response are described, or what contrast the author develops.

3. Remove examples that only illustrate a point. Names, dates, quotations, and statistics usually disappear unless they are essential to the meaning.

4. Check for distortion. A summary must keep the author's level of certainty and must not add advice, opinions, or conclusions the text never makes.

Tips that save time

- Use the 20-second test. After reading an option, ask: If this were the only sentence I remembered

- tomorrow, would I still understand what the passage was mainly about?
- Keep relationships. If the text explains cause and effect, comparison, problem-solution, or change over time, a strong summary usually preserves that relationship.
- Match the scope. For a paragraph-summary question, summarize only that paragraph or section - not

the entire passage.

Worked example

A city library tested Sunday hours for three months. Attendance was lower than on weekdays but higher than staff had predicted. Surveys showed that visitors used the library for studying, job applications, children's programs, and computer access. The library board will compare attendance, staffing costs, and survey feedback before deciding whether to continue Sunday service.

Which statement best summarizes the passage?

A. Libraries should remain open every Sunday because many people need computers. B. A library is testing Sunday hours and will use several kinds of evidence to decide whether the service should continue. C. Visitors used the library for studying, job applications, children's programs, and computer access. D. Sunday attendance was lower than weekday attendance.

Answer: B

B keeps the trial, its purpose, and the decision process. C and D are real details but too narrow. A adds a recommendation the passage does not make.

Why the tempting answers fail: C and D are tempting because they are true. Summary questions often use true details as distractors.

Common traps

- Too broad. The choice says something generally true about the topic but goes beyond the passage.
- Too narrow. The choice summarizes only one example, paragraph, or event.
- Detail-heavy. The choice repeats several facts but never gives the larger point.
- Added claim. The choice includes an opinion, recommendation, cause, or result not stated or supported.
- Lost relationship. The choice mentions the right facts but changes how they are connected.

If you keep missing this skill

If your answer contains several names, dates, numbers, or examples, ask whether you are retelling instead of summarizing. If your answer is so general that it could fit many different passages, it is probably too broad.

Quick check

1. A school replaced disposable lunch trays with reusable trays for six weeks. Waste volume fell, but washing required more staff time. The school is reviewing both results before choosing a permanent system.

Write a one-sentence summary that keeps both the benefit and the tradeoff.

2. Paragraph: Researchers tested two coatings on rooftop panels. One coating reflected more sunlight, while the other lasted longer in wet conditions. The team plans to test a third coating that may combine both advantages.

What are the two essential ideas that a summary of this paragraph should keep?

Quick check answers

1. Possible answer: A school's reusable-tray trial reduced waste but increased washing labor, so the school is weighing both effects before deciding what to do next.

2. The coatings have different strengths, and the researchers want to test another option that may combine those strengths.